

AN ANALYSIS OF POLITICAL POWER THEMES IN KEMI ADETIBA'S *KING OF BOYS*

By

Abdulqowiyu Adeyemi Usman

Kwara State University, Nigeria.

abdulqowiyu.usman@kwasu.edu.ng

ABSTRACT

Nollywood shapes public understanding of Nigeria's complex socio-political landscape. Films articulate societal power dynamics, including wealth aspirations and "big-manism", offering a platform for "political critique" and commentary on governance. Kemi Adetiba's *King of Boys* directly engages with these power themes. Nigeria's political landscape features intricate power struggles and opaque links between elites and organised crime. While Nollywood portrays corruption, a distinctive semiotic analysis of how *King of Boys* constructs these complex connections is needed, especially considering historical negative portrayals of powerful women in Nollywood. This study aims to critically analyse political power themes in *King of Boys*. It seeks to examine how semiotic elements convey power dynamics, deconstruct symbolic links between characters/institutions and Nigerian political realities, and investigate the film's depiction of the illicit relationship between political elites and organised crime. Employing qualitative textual analysis of *King of Boys*, this research applies Ferdinand de Saussure's and Charles Sanders Peirce's semiotic theories. The methodology identifies and interprets signs within the film's narrative, characters, and visuals to deconstruct its "media language and conventions" and reveal messages about power and corruption. *King of Boys* boldly depicts complex power relations in Nigerian politics, illustrating pervasive ties between elites and criminal syndicates. Semiotic codes portray "big-manism" and absolute power. The film uses its female protagonist to explore gendered power dynamics within a male-dominated system, acting as a "site of resistance" against societal issues. *King of Boys* is a potent cinematic text interrogating Nigerian political power dynamics. Its sophisticated semiotic language provides insights into the symbiotic relationship between political leadership and organized crime, reflecting a "sad socio-political reality". Nollywood significantly contributes to critical social commentary. Further research into audience reception of *King of Boys*'

semiotic messages and comparative analyses of films with similar themes, especially those featuring powerful female protagonists, are recommended. Continued investigation into "political critique in Nigerian films" is also suggested.

Keywords: Nigerian politics, Power dynamics, Semiotics, *King of Boys*, Nollywood.

INTRODUCTION

Power is the capacity to control, influence, or exert authority over others. (Ramlan Surbakti, 2020) defines it as the ability to achieve desired goals. It drives change across social, economic, political, cultural, and religious domains. Power without love is reckless and abusive, while love without power is weak and ineffective. Ideally, power advances justice, and justice channels power to remove barriers to love. Martin Luther King Jr. viewed power as neutral, usable for good or ill, with its value determined by leaders' application toward higher aims (Remi, 2015). Power diffused throughout all governance forms, from dictatorships and monarchies to democracies, enabling dominance over others. Understanding power requires examining language's role in its expression and maintenance, as it shapes societal perceptions and actions (Swetha & Aravind, 2025). Democracy is the dominant global governance system and primary measure of government effectiveness. Ideally, it allows all adults to participate directly or through elected representatives. Yet, in developing countries, it often deviates from this ideal: voters' preferences rarely shape elections. Instead, candidates' money, coercive power (formal and informal), and skill in using it influence voters and actors more than ideologies or platforms (Samarzija, 2020). Nigeria's democracy since 1999 shows elites' ambitions overriding public interests. For example, in 2007, outgoing President Olusegun Obasanjo handpicked Umaru Yar'Adua as successor, ignoring party input. Likewise, former Lagos Governor Bola Tinubu reportedly selected all successors since 2007. Nigerian cinema conveys politics through allegories of kingship, as in Tunde Kelani's *Saworoide*, a satire on traditional rulers and democracy. *King of Boys* emerges from a turbulent context, highlighting instability, power struggles, godfatherism, and machinations.

Literary and artistic works reflect their socio-political environments, as seen in Nigerian writers like Wole Soyinka, Bode Sowande, Femi Osofisan, and musician Fela Anikulapo-Kuti. Similarly,

films capture a nation's economic, social, political, religious, cultural, and technological shifts, with *King of Boys* directly addressing contemporary political contentions. Numerous scholars have studied Nigerian cinema and its film industry, either broadly or focusing on specific films. Key works include Jonathan Haynes's analysis of public views on filmmakers and the mismatch between their films and societal realities (Haynes, 2006); Lasisi's critique that films neglect social and developmental issues, favouring miracle-based resolutions over practical solutions; and Haynes and Onookome's discussion of the shift from implausible stories to realistic depictions of religion, politics, culture, and production technologies. Film-specific studies, especially on *King of Boys*, include Emwinromwankhoe Osakpolor's *Portrayal of Women in Contemporary Nollywood Films: Isoken and King of Boys in Focus* and Oluwafemi Sunday Onifade's *Beyond the Lens: Kemi Adetiba's King of Boys as a Metaphor for Power and Order in Democratic Nigeria*. Theoretical foundations draw from Robert A. Dahl's Concept of Power, which examines societal power structures and actors, and Remi Anifowose's "Power, Influence, Authority," in *Element of Politics* which shows elite manipulation of subordinates via examples.

Beyond Onifade's brief link between the film's godfatherism and real Nigerian politics, few studies deeply analyze power dynamics in *King of Boys*. This research fills that gap by comparing film events directly to Nigeria's political reality, advancing studies of political power. *King of Boys* clearly mirrors Nigeria's economic, social, religious, cultural, and political shifts.

LITERATURE REVIEW AND THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK

Power appears in various forms, such as physical, political, economic, judicial, national, international, presidential, military, and "bottom" power. Among social sciences, political science

focuses most on power. Remi Anifowose notes that a content analysis of major theorists—from Plato and Aristotle to Machiavelli, Hobbes, Pareto, and Weber—would show power as central to politics (Remi Anifowose, 2015). These thinkers extensively analyzed power and related ideas. Lord Acton, quoted by Anifowose in *Element of Politics* states that "power tends to corrupt, and absolute power corrupts absolutely" (Remi Anifowose, 2015).

Some scholars view politics as involving both power and influence. Harold Lasswell and Abraham Kaplan define politics as processes of shaping, distributing, and using power, answering "who gets what, when, and how." George Catlin sees politics as human relations of association, competition, submission, and control, with power as the goal.

Anifowose argues that power, influence, and authority are essential yet hard to define due to their ambiguity (Remi Anifowose, 2015). Power operates in markets, classrooms, sports, and relationships. Anifowose defines power as "the present means to secure some future apparent good" (RemiAnifowose, 2015). This equates power with wealth as a means to ends. Thomas Hobbes calls wealth a form of power, with life as ceaseless pursuit "after power after power."

Critics say viewing power as static, not relational, limits its use in political science. Political power stems from authority, granting command rights and obedience duties. Anifowose explains: "Power should be seen as a relationship among men, not a personal characteristic... It is an asymmetrical relation between the influencer and the influenced" (Remi Anifowose, 2015).

Power is relational and bilateral, requiring interactions. Leadership needs followers; power needs subjects. Effective power use considers the needs of those affected. This interplay is key to understanding power and labour dynamics in small-scale enterprises, where employer control, worker agency, and regulations shape labour outcomes.

POLITICAL POWER

Herbert Simon sees power as an asymmetrical link between individuals' behaviours. Feedback flows from the influenced (Z) to the influencer (Y), per Carl Friedrich's "rule of anticipated reactions." Z anticipates Y's preferences and adjusts accordingly, even without direct orders. For example, a new president's choices reflect not just past votes but expected future ones. This feedback makes power hard to measure, limiting even dictators like Hitler and Stalin (Remi Anifowose, 2015). Authority differs from power: it is viewed as legitimate, allowing compliance without ongoing coercion, unlike power that depends on force or manipulation (Schimpf et al., 2024). Legitimate power, typically linked to positions of authority, elicits voluntary compliance as it is viewed as normatively correct or appropriate in society.

Power is inherently relative. As Remi Anifowose notes, "the main problem is not to determine the existence of power but to make comparisons" (Remi Anifowose, 2015). Comparing actor Y's power to Z's requires a shared definition of power and standard metrics to measure its strength or absence. This issue fuels the elitist-pluralist debate in political science over power measurement methods. Studies of community power often show that key influencers work "behind the scenes," holding true power by setting agendas rather than just deciding public disputes (Remi Anifowose, 2015).

Robert Dahl views influence as central to power, defining it as "a relation among actors such that the wants, desires, preferences, or intentions of one or more actors affect the actions or predisposition to act, of one or more other actors" (Remi Anifowose, 2015). In practice, distinctions between power and influence are minor. Influence prompts action changes without threats of severe deprivation. Both are rational and relational, but power relies on potential

sanctions, while influence does not. Anifowose identifies two types of influence (Remi Anifowose, 2015):

- Coercive influence: Based on threats of severe penalties, such as punishment, torture, imprisonment, or death. John Locke called "political power" "a right of making laws, with penalties of death and consequently all less penalties."
- Reliable influence: Marked by likely compliance, as a true form of influence.

As (Remi, 2015) notes, influence divides into manifest (explicit) and potential (implicit) forms. Manifest influence occurs when Y's actions directly change Z's behaviour. Potential influence works implicitly: for example, National Assembly policymakers may consider unengaged groups like small business owners or students, allowing those groups to shape outcomes indirectly.

Relying mainly on force harms governments long-term. Leaders need their authority to be seen as legitimate by subjects. As Crick states:

“Probably, all governments require some capacity for or potentiality of force or violence, but probably no government can maintain itself through time as distinct from defense and attack at specific moments, without legitimating itself in some way, getting itself loved, respected, even just accepted as inevitable, otherwise it would need constant recourse to open violence which is rarely the case.”, (Crick, 2006)

DIFFERENTIATING AUTHORITY FROM POWER

Remi Anifowose distinguishes authority from power by positing that authority is power or influence recognized as rightful. It represents governance accepted as valid by supporters and

tolerated by opponents. Citizens confronted with mere power may legally support or resist it, but authority demands obedience; resistance is unlawful. Power is raw force, whereas authority is legitimized through consent. Opponents may submit to governmental power but not acquiesce voluntarily; compliance stems from compulsion, not allegiance (Remi Anifowose, 2015).

Authority employs imperative language, issuing direct commands unlike the persuasion of power or influence. For instance, a police officer demands, "Show your vehicle particulars," and the driver complies due to the officer's legal backing (Remi Anifowose, 2015). In contrast, an armed robber's order, "Give me your money," conceals a threat of violence, revealing its coercive nature. Thus, authority encompasses both, though not all power is strictly coercive; combining positive inducements with sanctions yields non-coercive power.

There are, hence, certain articles of faith and belief which surround authority and serve to legitimize its exercise. This is what Charles Merriam calls "the credenda of authority." They are the principles of legitimation used to justify power of command. They are also what the German political sociologist, Max Weber, "describes as the three main types of authority. These are: Legal/Rational Authority. Based on impartial rules. Leaders are elected or appointed legally; obedience follows the law, not individuals. Prevalent in modern democracies, where constitutional governments operate within legal bounds.

Traditional Authority. Rooted in longstanding customs. Rulers hold inherited status, blending tradition with personal discretion. Subjects obey from personal loyalty or respect for time-honored positions. Typical of pre-industrial societies.

Charismatic Authority. Derives from a leader's exceptional qualities (e.g., heroism or prophecy). Followers obey the individual, not rules or traditions. Examples include Mao Zedong, Hitler, Mussolini, de Gaulle, and Gandhi. Succession proves challenging due to its rarity.

Remi Anifowose (2015:117) observes that these sources of authority are not necessarily exclusive. They could be in various combinations or co-exist in specific political communities. These are pure types of authority and are unlikely to exist in their extreme forms. Britain, for example, has a government based largely on legal/rational authority but with some element of tradition (for example, the monarchy) and occasionally, some elements of charismatic leadership (for example, Winston Churchill). The state enables ordered cooperation for human flourishing. Political authority, government, coordinates collective efforts. Without it, chaos ensues; with insufficient authority, instability follows. Government wields command power, backed by force when needed. Citizens owe obedience to its just directives, a core civic duty. As Saint Paul writes (quoted in Remi Anifowose, 2015):

“Thou must be submissive, not only for fear of punishment, but in conscience. It is for this same reason that you pay taxes; magistrates are in God's service... pay every man, then his due, taxes, if it be taxes, customs, if it be customs, respect and honour, if it be respect and honour. This creates a mutual relationship: citizens owe obedience and financial support to the state, which must serve a higher moral or divine order. This view reflects a deontological approach to civic duty, treating obedience to state directives as a moral obligation, not just a practical choice, regardless of short-term results (Abumere, 2021).

THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK

This study employs semiotics theory from Ferdinand de Saussure and Charles Sanders Peirce. The theory applies across fields like philosophy, linguistics, arts, literature, archaeology, architecture, and mathematics (Yakin and Totu, 2014). It emerged in 1916, after Saussure's death in 1913 and Peirce's in 1914. Scholars distinguish semiotics as two concepts (Alexandru, 2014).

In this research, film elements in *King of Boys*, such as characters, plots, institutions, act as signs representing real Nigerian events. Viewer-image links are subjective; people assign personal meanings consciously or subconsciously (Tom, 2014). Interpretations thus vary from the director's intent due to individual backgrounds and cognition.

Media literacy is essential for semiotic analysis. Meaning arises from the interpreter, not symbols. Message significance depends on the recipient's knowledge, background, and skills matching the sender's; mismatches cause miscommunication (Hanson, 2014). Literacy shapes sign decoding (Hanson, 2014). Low-literacy viewers see only surface content; skilled ones find deeper meanings (Goharipour, 2019).

Scenario construction involves data collection, analysis, and narrative communication (Nchez-Esguevillas, and Carro, 2017). This study uses Critical Discourse Analysis (Mikhaeil and Baskervillebc, 2019). Critical Discourse Analysis (CDA) covers texts, art, images, sculptures, and audiovisual media. It allows explicit researcher positions with rigor. Van Dijk calls it a "dissident" approach to "understand, expose, and ultimately resist social inequality."

This study states the author's views on Nigerian power dynamics and governance in the film. CDA examines "the way social power abuse, dominance, and inequality are enacted, reproduced, and resisted by text and talk in the social and political context" (Taiwo, 2007). It reveals how discourses

build knowledge (Taiwo, 2007). Critical Discourse Analysis (CDA) fits by addressing real issues, providing historical and social context for filmmakers' choices, and tackling inequalities.

King of Boys, directed by Kemi Adetiba, depicts Nigerian politics' links to crime. Central figure Alhaja Eniola Salami leads the underworld while laundering money via legal businesses like real estate, water, textiles, and bakeries. She seeks politics but faces betrayal over her criminal ties. This sparks subordinate disloyalty; one challenges her, triggering clashes with politicians and rivals. Eniola loses power but escapes via system flaws to the United States, and regains the control of the underworld remotely, thereby wielding enormous power in the Nigerian politics.

ABOUT THE SCREENWRITER, PRODUCER, AND DIRECTOR

Kemi Adetiba (January, 1980), a distinguished Nigerian filmmaker, television and music video director, earned a bachelor's degree in law from the University of Lagos. Born in Lagos to parents Dele and Mayen Adetiba, she featured as a child in a television commercial for OMO detergent. In her personal life, she married Oscar Heman-Ackah in April 2022 following their engagement in January.

Adetiba began her career as a radio presenter at Rhythm 93.7 FM, voicing syndicated programmes Soul'd Out and Sunday at the Seaside. She anonymously released personal remixes online under the pseudonym 'hule' via Spotify and Sound Cloud. Transitioning to television, she produced and hosted MNet shows such as Studio 53 and Temptation Nigeria, presented on Sound city TV, and hosted Maltina Dance All for three seasons.

She refined her directing skills at the New York Film Academy. Her short film *Across a Bloodied Ocean* premiered at the 2009 Pan African Film Festival and National Black Arts Festival. Her

feature debut, *The Wedding Party*, opened the City-to-City Spotlight at the Toronto International Film Festival.

Her accolades include Best Female Video for TY Bello's "Ekundayo" and Omawumi's "Today na Today" (2010 Nigeria Entertainment Awards), alongside nominations for Best Music Video Director at The Headies 2014 and City People Entertainment Awards, and a HNWOTY Award for Woman of the Year in Film and Television. Key projects includes but not limited to *The Wedding Party*, *King of Boys*, and *King of Boys: The Return of the King*.

SYNOPSIS OF KING OF BOYS

King of Boys is a political thriller written and directed by Kemi Adetiba, clocking in at three hours and two minutes. The main cast features Sola Sobowale, Adesuwa Etomi-Wellington, Remilekun “Reminisce” Safaru, Ilibliss, Toni Tones, Paul Sambo, Jide Kosoko, Sharon Ooja, and Osas Ighodaro Ajibade. The story follows Alhaja Eniola Salami, whose early life was wrecked by her dad's abuse toward her mom. Later, working at a restaurant, she and her friends get sexually harassed by male customers. Rising above it all, Eniola becomes a tough, bold powerhouse with tons of connections, a do-gooder and businesswoman by day, but secretly ruling the criminal underworld at night, running shady businesses for cash. Using her charity work and ties, she boosts politicians like Aare into office. But when she goes for her own political spot, her old allies turn on her, citing her criminal past and ditching her dreams.

In the chaos, Makanaki, one of her underlings, rebels to take over. He teams up with Aare and politicians to bring her down. Eniola gets hit with charges like murder, money laundering, stealing public funds, and bribing cops, landing her in jail and court. She's cleared by Justice Nwachukwu,

but then her adopted daughter Kemi gets killed by a hitman, and her son Kitan, having killed his spy, dies right after committing suicide. This leads to her re-arrest, prison time, and losing everything. About to be taken out in jail, Officer Gobir steps in with key evidence, saving her and nailing Aare and his crew. Makanaki gets whacked by underworld guys, while Eniola bolts to Brooklyn, USA, and takes back control of Lagos's crime scene from afar.

ANALYSIS OF KEMI ADETIBA'S *KING OF BOYS*

King of Boys is a crime-political thriller. It highlights themes of power and politics. It also covers related issues like abuse, rape, and objectification of women. The central plot is a struggle for dominance. Kemi Adetiba reflects efforts to hide their crimes. Key themes of political power include godfatherism, corruption, bribery, manipulation, political thuggery, money laundering, intimidation, and undue influence.



King of Boys. Dir. Kemi Adetiba. www.netflix.com

In Nigeria, godfatherism is a harmful form of political corruption. A powerful patron picks a lesser-known proxy to hold office and exercise power. Godfathers are elite power brokers. Gaining a major political role often requires their support. This dynamic appears in the film's underworld and real Nigerian politics. For example, jailed Aare Akinwande, for money laundering, bribery, and corruption, receives a visit from Jumoke Randle, the governor's wife. She seeks his backing for her husband's reelection. Aare states, "Your husband forgot that we put him there. When it comes to politics, he believes that the match is won on the pitch, when in fact, you and I both know that it is decided in the back rooms long before the game has begun." He warns, "We have to stop the hand before it gets to the elbow, that's how we remain in power." Aare holds a strong influence even from prison. Godfatherism is standard in Nigerian politics, often called humility but driven by control. Success relies more on loyalty to godfathers than merit. Nigeria shows this clearly worldwide. In the film, Aare represents such a figure in crime circles, like Bola Tinubu's sway over officials. The TV series mirrors this: Aare denies Eniola Salami a promised ministerial post despite her aid. She faces framing, arrest, loss of her crime throne, and Makanaki's rise as a former Lagos governor, ousted for defying his godfather. Godfatherism remains a key route to power in Nigeria.



King of Boys. Dir. Kemi Adetiba. www.netflix.com

From the detention, Aare still wields political relevance. He put a call through to the president Mumusa, letting him know why it is of importance to eliminate Alhaja Eniola Salami who poses as a major obstacle for the president's reelection and their other business. Just then the president made it known to him that Alhaja Eniola Salami is now the official CNP gubernatorial governorship candidate of their party in Lagos State. Aare hisses, "rubbish" and hung up the call on the present. This action points us to how powerful godfathers are in Nigerian politics. Otunba Taiwo remarked that, "Aare is still very much a powerful political figure even in detention, and he is right! That woman is a problem". He calls for urgent move to take care of their problem before it gets out of hands. The president in his response, "you are absolutely right, Chief Taiwo. Unfortunately, we need her more than she needs us at the moment. We should focus on securing our second term. Once she does that for us, we can give clearer decision on how to eliminate our

problems”. The position of the president to halt taking hasty decision on Alhaja Salami speaks volume of how political office holders see winning an election and reelection over good governance. To achieve that, they must dance to the tune of their godfathers or whoever have their backings. As the law applies in Robert Greene’s 48 Laws of Power, Don’t outshine your master’; but it is on few cases where a stooge tries to outsmart his benefactor that he pays with losing a reelection – like in the case of the former Lagos State Governor, Akinwunmi Ambode with his boss, His Excellency, Bola Ahmed Tinubu.

Bribery and corruption are key themes. Corruption involves dishonest acts by officials, often through bribery, where favours are exchanged for influence. Bribery damages ethics in politics.



King of Boys. Dir. Kemi Adetiba. www.netflix.com

Eniola Salami donates to Reverend Ifeanyi's church to gain his endorsement for governorship, disguising it as a charitable gesture. Governor Randle's wife uses bribes such as church gifts and a prison visit with sexual advances to Aare, highlighting his influence. Adetiba exposes how religious leaders are involved in politics, as politicians see their support as a way to win votes.

Media manipulation helps politicians control narratives. In the series, journalist Oladapo Banjo faces threats to halt reports on Eniola's crimes and elite misconduct, including a bomb letter that kills a janitor, like Dele Giwa's 1986 murder. His editor says, "He refused to acknowledge that there are some stories you don't pursue, and that got him killed," citing his father's death. This echoes Nigeria's truth suppression amid manipulation. Social media now spreads false stories for gain.

On the other hand, Alhaja Salami, on a secret visit to the president, said emphatically, "How can I be the one who put you there? Have you forgotten? I want to be the official gubernatorial candidate under your party. And if you return, I will do what you want." The president said, "It is as if you have started using those drugs you are selling," to which she responded, "Tread carefully, sir. Never you forgetting who you are speaking to." The president, however, made it clear to Alhaja Salami that her request was impossible because the party already had a candidate who had been campaigning for over a year. "...then you will lose your seat in the next election," said Alhaja Salami. "You cannot do that. We have a deal," the president retorted. "Deal? Oh yes! We had a deal. My obligation has been fully fulfilled. Aren't you the president? Now, tell me your obligations to me. Did you fulfil your promise? So, you thought you could slap me in the face and I would turn the other cheek..." The president then proposed an offer that she should start with a position in the House of Representatives or even the Senate, claiming he could make it happen with his eyes closed. He further reiterated that what Alhaja Salami was asking for was impossible.

He said, "You know I can only be beneficent to you if I remain in power." In the unfolding narrative, the president was supposed to bring Alhaja Salami back home from exile once he became president. That was part of the deal; instead, he left her to languish in exile for three years. Again, he taunted her with his ambition for a second term in office, remarking that he had suddenly remembered his old friends. She spoke emphatically, "You and your party, back me as the governor of Lagos State. Or else, I will use every resource I have and make sure Rtd. Admiral Peterside is president in eight months. Just to spite you." "Let me talk to the elders of the party and see what we can do." This is a testament to how political office holders bend to the dictates of their benefactors to the detriment of their awareness of their illegal businesses they operate—like in the case of Alhaja Eniola Salami, where the president warns her to keep her nose clean so as not to drag the party she demands support from into the mud. Her further request corroborates the president's inability to uphold the rule of law due to his previous engagement with Alhaja Salami. She said, "Oh, before I forget, president, I want all my accounts unfrozen and access to all my property."



King of Boys. Dir. Kemi Adetiba. www.netflix.com

Eniola threatens the President: without his party's gubernatorial ticket, he will lose. He offers funds for another bid, but she demands his platform. Nigeria's dominant parties; People's Democratic Party and All Progressives Congress, resist strong challengers.

Political thuggery undermines democracy through violence. Politicians hire criminals to intimidate rivals. Thugs gain leverage; elites get enforcement. Adetiba shows this alliance. Banjo exposes Eniola's election rigging for the President's pardon upon her US return, a trade of her crime influence for his protection.

RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

Kemi Adetiba's film examines Nigerian politics. This analysis explores characters, settings, and institutions for symbolic parallels to real Nigerian events, figures, and organizations. The film highlights ethnic dimensions in crime and law enforcement. Voter education aims to boost political engagement and accountability (Fafchamps and Vicente, 2013). The film shows southern ethnic groups dominating organized crime, while Hausa-Fulani groups guard the socio-economic system. Yoruba and Igbo Nigerians are highly mobile globally. Their successful members benefit host countries, but disreputable ones harm Nigeria's image. The U.S. FBI recently noted this (Ejiogu, and Ambituuni, 2019).

Detective Nurudeen Gobir represents anti-corruption efforts as an officer in the Nigerian Corruption Crime Commission (Song, Chang, and Gong, 2020). He reports to a Hausa-Fulani

superior (Nwogu, Onojeghen, and Peter, 2019). Corruption affects all areas of Nigerian public administration. Political elites often divert infrastructure funds (Onifade and Abati, 2019). Public office is seen as the fastest path to wealth, driving extreme actions (Onifade and Abati, 2019). Corruption also fuels political violence, as hired thugs target civilians after elections.

In the film, the party chairman loses \$45 million to underworld figures but avoids reporting it, since the funds were illicit. This mirrors cash found at the start of President Buhari's administration. Even anti-corruption agencies face corruption (Ojeka, Adegboye, Umukoro, Dahunsi, and Ozordi, 2019). Inspector Gobir is undermined by his superior, who aids corrupt politicians. In reality, EFCC chairs like Nuhu Ribadu, Farida Waziri, and Ibrahim Lamorde faced corruption charges and were removed. Acting Chairman, Ibrahim Magu awaits Senate confirmation amid similar issues, later got cleared and had his hands soiled in the end. In Nigeria, positions depend on parochial influences, not merit (Aregbeshola, 2016). For instance, before recent elections, godfathers blocked All Progressives Congress gubernatorial aspirants in Ogun State. This incident coincide with the dropping of the NCNC Governorship candidate for the candidacy of Alhaja Eniola Salami having met with President Mumusa in closed doors.

Kemi Adetiba's *King of Boys* (2018) and its sequel act as a mirror to the Nigerian political climate, using fictional characters to expose the deep, often violent, entanglement of organized crime, godfatherism, and high-stakes corruption. Through Eniola Salami, the film dramatizes how the Nigerian political class maintains power through coercion, betrayal, and the manipulation of democratic processes.

Key reflections of the Nigerian political climate in the movie include:

Godfatherism and Corruption: The plot highlights how politicians and criminal kingpins operate in tandem, utilizing "unseen hands" to secure electoral victory and control state resources.

The Politics of Violence: The film mirrors the reality of political thuggery and the use of violent intimidation by elite players to settle scores and eliminate opposition.

Gender and Power: The protagonist, a ruthless woman in a male-dominated arena, highlights the intersection of gender, ambition, and the struggle to assert authority in a misogynistic political environment.

Socio-Economic Inequality: The film depicts the sharp contrast between the opulent, corrupt lifestyle of the elite and the grinding poverty of the masses, often showing wealth meant for the public being stashed away by political actors.

Post-Military Political Structure: The narrative reflects the aftermath of long military rule, showcasing a democracy plagued by fraudulent, non-credible elections and a lack of transparency.

King of Boys acts as a "metaphor for power and order" in contemporary Nigeria, painting a grim but realistic picture of how political authority is achieved and maintained.

CONCLUSION/RECOMMENDATION

Power dynamics and social order pose complex challenges in emerging democracies like Nigeria. *King of Boys* boldly captures these intricate political structures. While a full depiction is impossible, the film's characters, institutions, themes, and settings closely reflect Nigeria's political reality. It serves key media functions, surveillance and correlation, by highlighting links between

politicians and crime syndicates. Nigeria's social order relies on power balances between elites and the criminal underworld. The film's elements act as signs that encapsulate Nigeria's political and social truths. Perceptive viewers' spot ties to real events, but others may miss them. This supports de Saussure and Sanders' view that interpretations of signs are subjective. Some audiences see only entertainment; others uncover political, cultural, economic, and historical insights. The film preserves contemporary Nigerian politics for future generations. More filmmakers should depict these issues from varied perspectives to offer diverse views of Nigeria's political complexities.

REFERENCES

- Aberian, G & Masannat, S (1970) *Contemporary Political Systems: An Introduction to Government*. New York: Charles Scribner's & Sons
- Akinbade, J.A. (2004). *Dictionary of Nigerian Government and Politics*. Lagos: Macak Books Ltd.
- Anifowose, R. (2015). "Power, Influence, Authority" in *Elements of Politics*. Edited by Remi Anifowose and Francis Enemu. Sam Ironsi Publications, Lagos.
- Laswell, H. & Kaplan, A. (2019). *Power and Society: A Framework for Political Inquiry*. New Haven: Conn, Yale University Press.
- Bendix, R. (2019). *Max Weber: An Intellectual Portrait*. London, p. 290
- Barry, N. P., (1981). *An Introduction to Modern to Modern Theory*. Macmillan, London, pp 72 – 73

Catlin, G. (2017). *A Study of the Principles of Politics*. Alien & Unwin, London.

Charles, M. (2018). *Political Power*. London, Collier – Macmillan Ltd., pp188 – 127. Ibid, pp, 119 – 132

Crick, B. (2006). “Basic Concepts for Political Education” in *B. Crick and A. Porter, (eds.), Political Education and Political Literacy*, Longman, London.

Dahl, R. (2020). “The Concept of Power.” *Behavioural Science*. Vol.2, pp. 201 – 15

Dyke, V. (1960). *Political Science: A philosophical Analysis*. Stanford University Press, pp. 131 – 4.

Freidrich, C. (1963). *Man, and His Government*. McGraw Hill Book Co. New York. Pp 201-2

Haynes, J. (2006). *Nigeria Video Films*. Ohio University Press, Athens, OH, pp. 209-41

Locke, J. (1992). *Two Treatise of Government*. J.M. Dent & Sons Ltd., London.

Marshall, C. & Rossman, H. (1999). ‘Designing Qualitative Research’. 3rd Ed. Sage Publications, London.

Okome, O. & Haynes, J. (1995). *Cinema and Social Change in Nigeria* (72-83). Jos: Nigeria Film Corporation.

Ogunleye, F. (2003). *The Innocent Victim in Ogunleye Foluke’s the Innocent Victim and Plays*. Swaziland: TTI Publishing Ltd.

Ruseel, B. (1999). *Power: A New Social Analysis*. London, Alien & Univ. p.25

Simon, H. (2008). “Notes on the Observation and Measurement of Political Power.” Ibid, pp. 366

– 7

Alike, E., Francis S., John S., and Onuminya I. (2019). "Two Months after, Sokoto, Zamfara, Katsina Count GAINS of Amnesty for Bandits." *This day Newspaper*.

Aregbeshola, B. S. (2016). "Institutional Corruption, Health-Sector Reforms, and Health Status in Nigeria." *The Lancet Journal* 388(10046):757.

Damayanti, N. L. and Medhy A. H. (2019). "Hiperreality Of Social Media: A phenomenology Study of Self-Confession of Housewives of Facebook Users." *The Journal of Society and Media* 3(2).

Derboven, J., Dries De R., and Mathijs V.(2012). "Semiotic Analysis of Multi-Touch Interface Design: The MuTable Case Study." *International Journal of Human-Computer Studies* 70(10):714–28.

Ejiogu, A., Chibuzo E., and Ambisizi A. (2019). "The Dark Side of Transparency: Does the Nigeria Extractive Industries Transparency Initiative Help or Hinder Accountability and Corruption Control?" *Journal : The British Accounting Review* 51(5).

Endong, F. P. 2019. "Documenting Nigeria's Social and Cultural History through Cinema: A Study of Biyi Bandele's *Half of a Yellow Sun* and Kunle Afolayan's *October 1*." IGI Global Website.

Fafchamps, M. and Pedro C. V. (2013). "Political Violence and Social Networks: Experimental Evidence from a Nigerian Election." *Journal of Development Economics* 101:27–48.

Goharipour, H. (2019). "Narratives of a Lost Space: A Semiotic Analysis of Central Courtyards in Iranian Cinema." *Journal of Frontiers of Architectural Research* 8(2):164–74.

Hanson, R. E. (2014). *Mass Communication: Living in a Media World*. Loss Angeles: Sage Publication.

Ikporukpo, C. O. 1986. "Politics and Regional Policies: The Issue of State Creation in Nigeria." *Journal of Political Geography Quarterly* 5(2):127–39.

Isumonah, V. A. (2015). "Minority Political Mobilization in the Struggle for Resource Control in Nigeria." *Journal of the Extractive Industries and Society* 2(4):645–53.

Iyoboyi, M. (2012). "The Political Economi of Poverty in Nigeria." *International Journal of Research in Commerce, Economic and Management* 2008.

Klantschnig, Gt. (2016). "The Politics of Drug Control in Nigeria: Exclusion, Repression and Obstacles to Policy Change." *International Journal of Drug Policy* 30:132–39.

Mahmood, I. (2016). "Influence and Importance of Cinema on the Lifestyle of Educated Youth: A Study on University Students of Bangladesh." *IOSR Journal of Humanities and Social Science* 77–80.

Mikhaeil, C. A. and Richard L. B. (2019). "Using Semiotics to Analyse Representational Complexity in Social Media." *Journal of Information and Organization* 29(4).

Mohamadi, F. 2016. "Making a Sociological Inquiry about the Role of Films in Lifestyle." *International Journal of Research in Humanities*

Nelson, O., Grace L., and Oladokun O. (2018). "Bloggng, Civic Engagement, and Coverage of Political Conflict in Nigeria: A Study of Nairaland.com." *Kasetsart Journal of Social Sciences* 39(2):291–98.

Ogundipe, S. (2018). "Governor Ortom Speaks as Army Arrests Aide for 'Masterminding' Benue Killings." *The Premium Times*, April 18.

Ojeka, S., Alex A., Kofo A., Olaoluwa U., Olajide D. and Emmanuel O. (2019). "Corruption Perception, Institutional Quality and Performance of Listed Companies in Nigeria." *Journal of Heliyon* 5(10).

Oluwamayowa, G. V., and Paul A. O. (2019). "The Enactment of Ideology and Self-Presentation in Political Campaign Videos of the 2015 General Election in Nigeria." *Journal of Discourse, Context and Media* 28:121–30.

Omoera, O. S. and Enuwa, E. O. (2019). "Neo-Colonial Dependence and Dualistic Development Models: An Exploration of the Development Communication Trajectory in Nigeria." *The Journal of Society and Media* 3(2).

Onifade, O. S. and Mobolaji. O. A.(2019). "Rearticulating Corruption: An Assessment of Selected Newspapers' Narratives on Atiku Abubakar's Strategic Foreign Trips." *Sub-Saharan African Journal of Humanities and Social Science* 161–72.

Pulse.ng. 2019. "Katsina Governor Says Negotiation with Bandits Yielding Results." *Pulse Ng*, September 22.

Samarzija, S. P. (2020). "The Epistemology of Democracy: The Epistemic Virtues of Democracy." *Journal: Filozofijai Drustvo* 31(1):56–70.

Song, C., Chun-Ping C., and Qiang G. (2020). "Economic Growth, Corruption, and Financial Development: Global Evidence." *Economic Modelling Journal*.

Stoycheff, E. (2020). “No Title Relatively Democratic: How Perceived Internet Interference Shapes Attitudes about Democracy.” *The International Journal of Press/Politic*.

Taiwo, R. (2007). “Language, Ideology and Power Relations in Nigerian Newspaper Headlines.” *Nebula Journal* 218–45.

Tayo, A. O. (2018). “*King of Boys* Is a Movie That Nollywood Needs Right Now.” *Pulse*. Ng.

Tom, E. W. (2014). “Social Constructs in Film Culture: The Effect of It on the Performing Arts, and the Destroyed Association of Signs to Enhance Meaning.” *Portland State University*.

Williamson, J. B. and Fred C. P. (1991). “Ethnic Politics, Colonial Legacy, and Old Age Security Policy: The Nigerian Case in Historical and Comparative Perspective.” *Journal of Aging Studies* 5(1):19–44.

Yakin, H. S. Mohd & Andreas T. (2014). “The Semiotic Perspectives of Peirce and Saussure: A Brief Comparative Study.” *Procedia Journal - Social and Behavioral Sciences* 155:4–8.

FILMOGRAPHY

King of Boys. Directed by Kemi Adetiba. [WWW.Netflix](http://www.netflix.com). Com